

phases of the games err strongly towards shorter lengths. That hard length, pitching 8–10 metres from the batsman's stumps, is hard to hit at that speed. If Mayank can also work on an effective slower ball, something that is now an important feature of death bowling, it might help him if he is summoned between overs 17 and 20.

Mayank also brings a third advantage: his height. Standing at 6 feet 1 inch, he releases the ball from a considerable height. When the release point is that high, the line becomes doubly important. Therefore, his key strength as a bowler lies in his ability to control the line effectively, making him well-suited to execute this strategy due to his skill and physique.

Rohit Sharma prefers to have a bowling unit that includes at least one specialist spinner, along with three fast bowlers and at least one all-rounder. Mohammed Siraj and Bumrah are guaranteed to play in the XI. With Mohammed Shami all but ruled out of the T20 World Cup as he recovers from an ankle surgery, the third fast bowler, if India plays a six-man attack, could be a tussle between Mayank and possibly Arshdeep Singh or Mukesh.

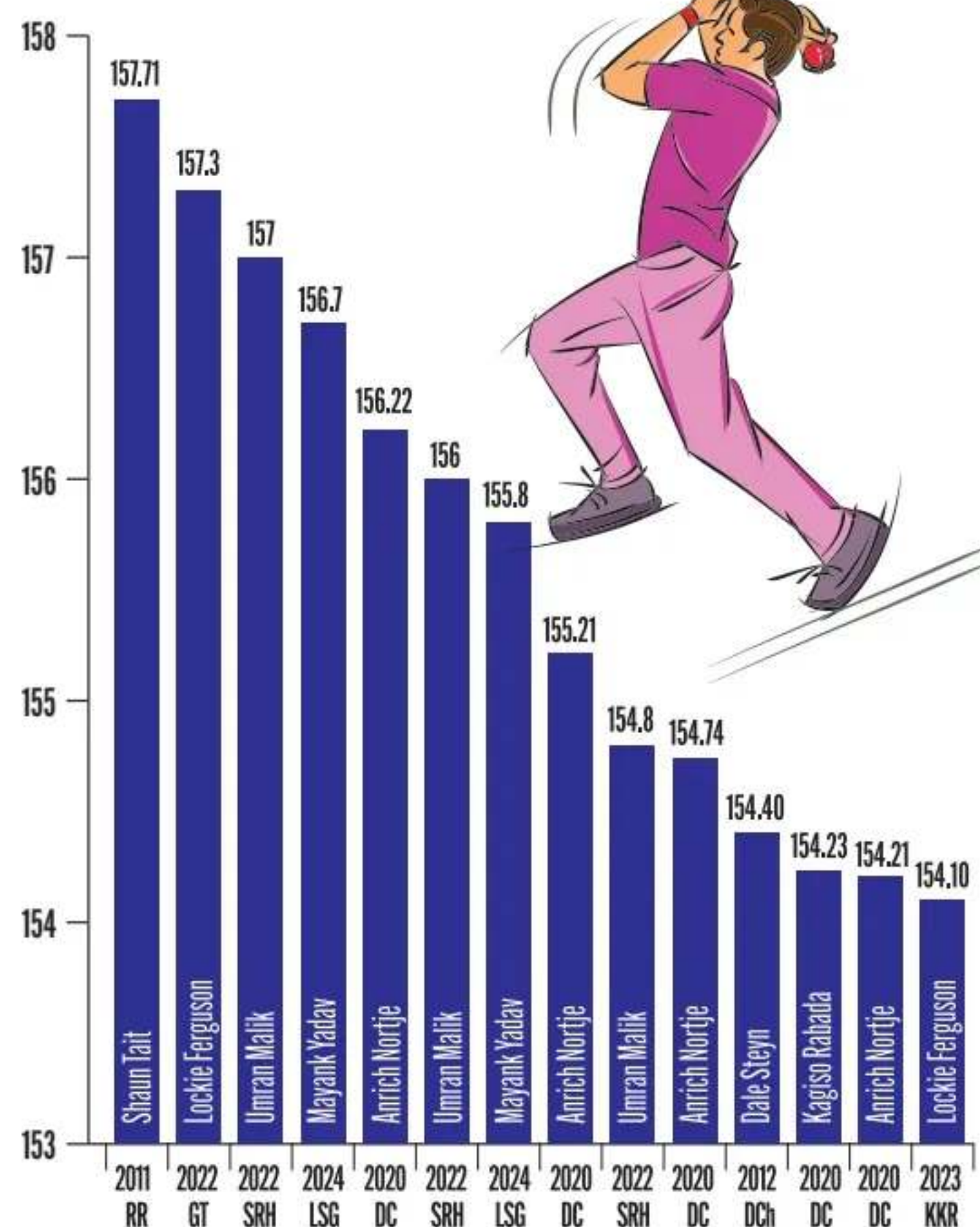
That said, these are still early chapters of Mayank's story. He will no doubt play matches in which he needs to dig deeper to make things happen. "When a young cricketer enters the scene causing excitement, both in terms of potential and performance, and progresses to playing more matches, particularly at the IPL and international levels, the intensity and pressure on their body increase significantly," Paranjpe said.

"Longevity becomes crucial for fast bowlers, making workload management imperative. So, let's not get carried away and instead give Mayank the space to express himself. From initial impressions, it's evident that he possesses the qualities to make an impact on the international stage. But discussing Mayank's participation in the T20 World Cup is premature; it would be more appropriate for him to complete a full season of first-class cricket first."

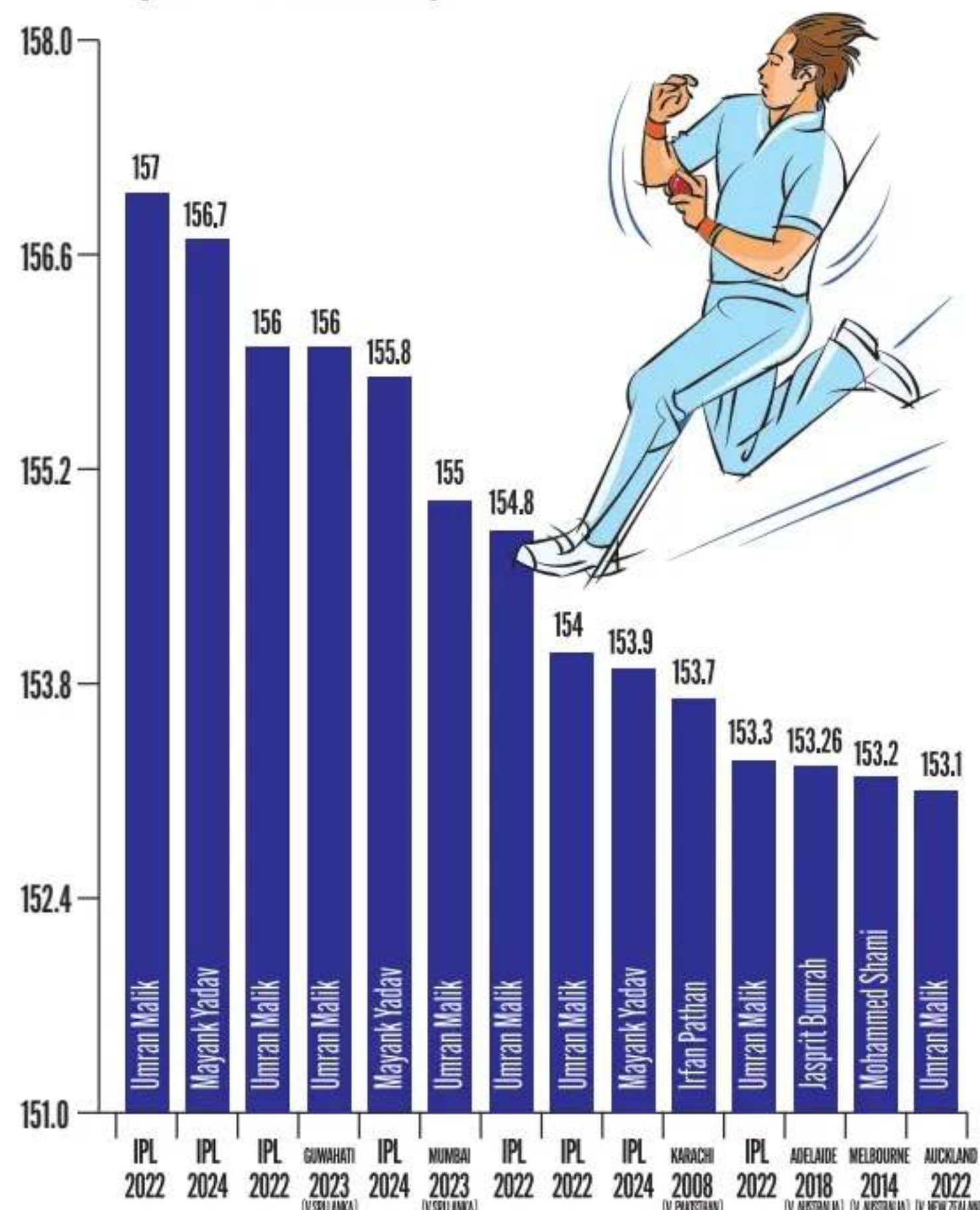
Bhave, however, begs to differ. "It's advantageous to give fast bowlers opportunities while they're still at their peak. In India, there's a tendency to subject fast bowlers to the grind of first-class cricket, leading some to lose their pace or skills over time."

Mayank, of course, must be groomed along the way with the right guidance and good facilities. While the excitement is understandable, the selectors will take a cue from the routes charted by another pace sensation, Umran. The Sunrisers Hyderabad

Fastest deliveries in IPL (where recorded)



Fastest deliveries by Indian bowlers (where recorded)



Statistics: Rajneesh Gupta